Samuel Raj—like many others in ISRO who never bothered to blow their own trumpets among the cacophony of self-promotion—died as an unsung hero soon after the first PSLV took to the skies in 1993.

After the welder impressed SEP with his skills, it was time for us to prove our utility when it comes to reviews and analysis. SEP had two technical bodies to review projects—Review Critique Definition and Review Critique Design. I was a member of the former. It defined and discussed specifications of an engine like operating pressure, stress levels and temperature. Looking at the results, it analysed if the specifications were achievable and, if they were not, it set new ones that were again dynamic. In short, it gave a direction to the development of a rocket engine.

Review Critique Design (RCD), on the other hand, was more critical when it came to understanding the 'know-why'. It went into why some specifications were not met. In other words, it analysed test failures. Earlier, blasts were not uncommon at rocket engine testing sites, but by now computers had taken the controls, aborting tests before they cross the danger mark. So, tests would leave us with many unanswered questions like when a test was aborted due to fluctuating pressure, was it because of pressure variation or the misbehavior of a pressure sensor (India was providing pressure-gauging transducers as part of the contract that got us to Vernon). The outcome of Review Critique Design analyses became inputs for the next test.

I decided to approach the men who mattered. And they were not very encouraging to the idea of an Indian trying to gain access to an exclusive club of analysts who designed future technologies of space. SEP honchos laughed when I expressed my wish to be part of Review Critique Design. Technology head Bachelot ruled it out upfront. Viking project director Dorville explained that SEP never allowed foreigners to be part of Review Critique Design; the few exceptions have been Europeans, given that SEP was part of the bigger European Space Agency.

I realised that request would not help. It was time to change tact. I had to impress upon the SEP top brass that I can bring to the RCD table something significant. I already had a little ammo. With help from my